

United Nations Commission on the Status of Women
Background Guide
SOMUN 2026

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Letter from the Chair

Dear Delegates,

It is my absolute pleasure to welcome you all to the United Nations Commission on the Status of Women (UNCSW), SOMUN 2026!

Before we begin, I would like every delegate to remember one thing: you are here to learn just as much as you are here to debate. Whether this is your first MUN or one of many, there is always something new to discover. You do not need to know everything, deliver the perfect speech, or have an answer to every question. What matters is your willingness to research, contribute, listen, and grow. Do not let nervousness prevent you from participating or make you feel that your ideas are not worth sharing. Every delegate has something valuable to bring to this committee, and I sincerely hope that each of you feels confident enough to make your voice heard.

To help you begin your preparation, this background guide introduces the committee and the agenda, provides relevant context, and offers a foundation upon which you can build your understanding. I strongly encourage you to read it carefully and use it as a starting point for your research. However, do not limit your preparation to this guide. Explore credible sources, examine your country's policies and position, understand the historical and political context, and look beyond the information presented here. The purpose of this guide is not to give you all the answers, but to help you ask better questions and develop informed, well-rounded perspectives.

Over the course of our three days together, I hope to see the committee evolve from establishing a strong understanding of the agenda to engaging in substantive debate, constructive negotiation, and the development of practical solutions. I encourage you to build upon the arguments presented, question thoughtfully, collaborate, and remain open to compromise. Above all, I request that every delegate participate actively.

As your Chair, I hope to provide an environment that is welcoming, respectful, and conducive to learning. Take risks, ask questions, learn from mistakes, and step outside your comfort zone. You may arrive with certain expectations, but I hope you leave with new perspectives, greater confidence, and knowledge that extends far beyond these three days.

I am genuinely excited to meet each and every one of you and witness the ideas, perspectives, and enthusiasm you bring to UNCSW. I look forward to three enriching days of thoughtful debate, meaningful collaboration, and memorable experiences. Let us make this committee one where we learn from one another, challenge ourselves, and work together towards outcomes we can be proud of.

Wishing you all the very best. I cannot wait to meet you and see what we accomplish together!

Best regards,
Sahana Pericherla - Chair
United Nations Commission on the Status of Women (UNCSW)

About the Committee

The Commission on the Status of Women (CSW) is the principal global intergovernmental body specifically committed to the promotion of gender equality and the empowerment of women and girls. It was established on 21 June 1946 by the United Nations Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC), of which it remains a functional commission.

The CSW's mandate includes advancing women's rights, examining the difficulties women and girls face, and developing global standards and recommendations to achieve gender equality. In 1996, the mandate of the organization was widened to encompass monitoring and assessment of the implementation of the Beijing Declaration and Platform for Action – one of the most important international frameworks for gender equality.

The Commission convenes annually for an official meeting at UN Headquarters in New York City. The representatives of the Member States, UN agencies, and non-governmental organizations participate in these meetings, discussing progress made, the problems that remain unsolved, and adopting conclusions that outline the steps that states and other stakeholders can take. The outputs of the CSW are then sent to ECOSOC for further discussion.

The Commission on the Status of Women consists of 45 Member States, elected by ECOSOC according to the principle of equitable geographic representation. UN Women provides assistance in the CSW's activities and promotes involvement of civil society.

This committee discusses how international cooperation and inclusive governance can help overcome obstacles to women's political agency, especially in conflict-ridden, unstable areas with violent extremism.

Overview of the Agenda

1. Understanding the Sahel and its contemporary context

The Sahel is a large geographical belt between the Sahara Desert to the north and the Sudanian savanna to the south. It consists of parts of various countries across West and Central Africa. According to discussions of security and political transitions, the central Sahel usually refers to Burkina Faso, Mali, and Niger. The broader regional context also includes countries around the Lake Chad Basin.

The region faces challenges of violent extremism, political instability, governance, humanitarian needs, poverty, climate-related pressures, and limited access to services. No single factor explains these issues.

The United Nations identified military takeovers, undemocratic governance, terrorism, poverty, and climate change among various other challenges being faced by West Africa and the Sahel. The importance of regional cooperation to address the root causes of conflict was also emphasized.

The UN’s regional approach identifies an interconnection between insecurity & institutional weaknesses and development challenges. Communities may face reduced access to justice and political participation when public institutions fail to deliver services, resolve disputes, or maintain public confidence and accountability. Armed conflict can disrupt education, livelihoods, and administration, further increasing difficulty in strengthening governance.

Military takeovers in Mali, Burkina Faso, and Niger have made the political situation in the central Sahel become particularly important and looked at. These transitions have created doubts and raised questions related to constitutional order, duration and inclusiveness of arrangements, the future of political participation, and cooperation between regional organizations.

The three countries subsequently formed the Alliance of Sahel States (AES) and withdrew from the Economic Community of West African States (ECOWAS), with their withdrawals taking effect in January 2025. These developments have reshaped regional political and security cooperation.

2. Defining women's political agency

Women's political agency refers to the capacity of women to exercise meaningful choices and influence decisions or opinions in political and public life. It includes the ability to participate in political decision-making, stand for public office, vote, organize, express opinions politically, contribute to peace negotiations, and hold public institutions accountable.

Political agency extends beyond the numerical presence of women in elected or appointed positions. Meaningful participation requires opportunities to influence decisions, access information, organize freely, and contribute to the design and implementation of policies.

The United Nations' Women, Peace and Security (WPS) agenda recognizes women as both individuals affected by conflict and active participants in conflict prevention, peace negotiations, peacebuilding, and reconstruction. It emphasizes the importance of women's participation at all levels of decision-making and the need to address the specific risks and barriers women experience in conflict and post-conflict environments.

In the Sahel, women can take part in politics in various ways:

- Political participation: running for public office, joining political parties, taking part in elections, working in legislatures, and public administration.
- Peace and security processes: getting involved in mediations, conflict prevention, taking part in peace negotiations, and helping bring communities together.
- Civil society engagement: being part of women's organizations, fighting for human rights, taking part in public discussions, and monitoring governance.
- Local decision-making: helping solve community problems, managing resources, and working on projects that make the local areas safer.

These forms of participation are complementary. Women's involvement in community peacebuilding can contribute to conflict prevention, but it should not substitute for their inclusion in formal political institutions.

3. Why women's political agency is under pressure

The agenda identifies three interconnected sources of pressure: military transitions, violent extremism, and weakening state institutions.

Military changes and political limits: When a military takeover happens, it can change how elected institutions work. It can also change how political parties act, how electoral bodies operate, and how public accountability is carried out. If the transitional arrangements reduce competition or give too few chances for public consultation, women may lose the formal ways they can influence policy and governance.

Violent extremism and insecurity: Armed violence can limit people's freedom to move about, disrupt education and their means of livelihood, cause the displacement of entire communities, and make it more difficult to take part in political or public activities. Women activists, local mediators, journalists, and community leaders may face additional obstacles when insecurity puts their safety at risk or hinders their ability to do their work.

Weakening of state institutions: The organisations in charge of elections, the administration of justice, public administration, and law enforcement may find it difficult to function effectively or to act independently. If legal protections are not put into effect, women will have limited access to remedies against discrimination, intimidation, or exclusion from political life.

These difficulties reinforce. Insecurity weakens institutional capacity, and limits on political participation reduce opportunities for accountability and inclusive conflict resolution. The United Nations' regional reports regard the security and governance problems in the Sahel as being interconnected rather than as separate issues.

4. The regional and international framework

The United Nations and the various regional organizations in Africa have set up frameworks that are relevant to women's involvement in governance, peacebuilding, and security.

The global framework that is most directly applicable is the Women, Peace and Security agenda, which was set up by United Nations Security Council Resolution 1325 in 2000; this agenda calls for greater involvement by women in conflict prevention, in conflict resolution, in peace processes, in peacekeeping and in post-conflict reconstruction, while also stressing the need to protect women's rights in conflict situations.

Other relevant instruments and frameworks include:

- The Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination against Women (CEDAW) looks at discrimination against women, including the obstacles they face in taking part in political and public life.
- The Beijing Declaration and Platform for Action of 1995 regarded as important areas for action women in positions of power and in decision-making, women's human rights, and women and armed conflict.
- Sustainable Development Goal 5 is about promoting gender equality and empowering women; specifically, Target 5.5 aims at ensuring women's full and effective participation and equal opportunities in leadership.
- The Maputo Protocol provides an African regional framework for women's rights, which includes their participation in political and decision-making processes.

The United Nations Office for West Africa and the Sahel (UNOWAS) promotes preventive diplomacy, supports inclusive political processes and regional cooperation, and also has the task of ensuring coherence in the international and regional responses to the root causes and consequences of conflict in the Sahel.

UN Women contributes by running programmes aimed at achieving gender equality, promoting women's political participation, and implementing the WPS agenda. Its regional activities have involved training women to act as mediators, supporting efforts to prevent community conflicts, and establishing partnerships with governments and regional organizations.

Historical Aspects

1. The development of the international women, peace and security framework

The international recognition of women's roles in peace and security grew over a number of decades, and this was finally achieved with the passage of United Nations Security Council Resolution 1325 in the year 2000.

1995 — Beijing Declaration and Platform for Action

The Beijing Declaration and Platform for Action were adopted at the Fourth World Conference on Women, thus setting up a global framework for promoting women's rights and gender equality. The conference regarded as important areas needing international action the position of women in power and decision-making, women's human rights, and the issue of women and armed conflict.

31 October 2000 — Security Council Resolution 1325

The Security Council passed Resolution 1325 unanimously, thereby setting up a significant international framework concerning women's involvement in conflict prevention, conflict resolution, peacebuilding, and post-conflict reconstruction. The resolution called for a greater representation of women at all levels of decision-making and stressed the need to protect women's rights in conflict situations.

2008–2019 — Expansion of the WPS framework

The various resolutions passed by the Security Council went on to develop and make clearer different parts of the agenda, such as conflict-related sexual violence, the involvement of women in peace processes, questions of accountability, and the implementation of measures. Thus, resolutions 1820 (2008), 1889 (2009), 1960 (2010), 2122 (2013), 2242 (2015), 2467 (2019) and 2493 (2019) helped shape this developing framework.

The WPS framework is especially relevant to the Sahel since it states that women should take part in decisions concerning security and political reconstruction and not be looked at merely in terms of the humanitarian effects of conflict.

2. 2012–2013: The Sahel's regional security crisis and the UN's integrated response

The period around 2012 marked a crucial turning point in the Sahel's security environment, especially in Mali, where a political and security crisis unfolded alongside the expansion of armed groups' influence in parts of the north.

To address the region's broader security concerns, the UN adopted a comprehensive approach that considered governance, security, resilience, and development.

In June 2013, the Secretary-General submitted his Report on the Situation in the Sahel Region (S/2013/354), which contained the United Nations Integrated Strategy for the Sahel. This strategy was adopted by the Security Council in 2013, and it aimed at addressing the root causes

and effects of the situation in the region through a coordinated approach in governance, security, and resilience.

This strategy also considered the aspect of human rights and women's participation, as well as the empowerment of youth. In this regard, the UN approach extended beyond security measures and considered long-term institutional development as well.

In relation to women's political engagement, this period is significant since it created a regional policy framework in which women's participation and gender equality can relate to conflict prevention and governance.

3. 2013–2020: Regional peacebuilding and women's participation

In subsequent years, UN bodies and regional counterparts launched programmes meant to boost women’s contribution to conflict prevention and peacebuilding in the Sahel.

According to UNOWAS in March 2020, 1,542 women mediators had been trained through regional women, peace, and security initiatives. The initiatives were meant to increase women’s contribution to conflict prevention, community reconciliation, and peacebuilding, among others, through collaboration with governments and regional bodies.

The programmes also contributed to women’s engagement with security stakeholders, including military personnel, administration, and judicial authorities. Cross-border programmes in areas bordering Mali and Niger tackled issues of community conflict and disputes over natural resources.

This shows how women’s contribution to the peace and security agenda in the Sahel region transcended the official level of national institutions. Community mediation, cross-border cooperation, and engagement with public authorities were part of the contributions.

Nevertheless, the fact that there were such initiatives did not mean that other challenges facing women did not exist. The political influence of women continued to be dependent on the security situation, institutional factors, resource availability, and participation in decision-making.

4. 2020–2023: Military takeovers and renewed political instability

There were several military takeovers that changed the political landscape in parts of West Africa and the Sahel.

August 2020 and May 2021 – Mali

There were two military takeovers in Mali in August 2020 and May 2021, which interfered with the political transition in the country and raised the issue of constitutional governance and returning to civilian government.

January and September 2022 – Burkina Faso

There were two military takeovers in Burkina Faso in 2022. These events prompted regional diplomatic activity and appeals to restore the constitutional order. In February 2022, there was a joint UNOWAS-ECOWAS mission after the January takeover.

Niger underwent a military takeover in July 2023, thus adding to the political uncertainty in the region and fueling debates over constitutional governance and regional response to military rule.

UN in its January 2023 brief raised the alarm on the destabilizing effect of coups and armed groups in West Africa and the Sahel. It also drew attention to the humanitarian implications of insecurity in terms of closing schools, displacement, and disruption of key services.

This is an important part of the agenda because political transitions may change the institutions that allow women to participate in political processes. Issues related

5. 2023–2025: Regional realignment and changing institutional arrangements

Many changes occurred with regard to regional cooperation after the coups.

Political and security cooperation among Mali, Burkina Faso, and Niger improved within the Alliance of Sahel States. These states left ECOWAS in January 2025, thus transforming the institutional framework of regional diplomatic and security cooperation. Mention should be made of the UN Security Council briefings on West Africa and the Sahel, held in April 2025, that touched upon these events.

At the same time, UN reports continued drawing attention to the issue of women's underrepresentation in transitional political processes.

Thus, in the Security Council Briefing, conducted by UN Women in August 2025, it was mentioned that women were underrepresented in some of the important national reform processes in the central Sahel region. Namely, it was mentioned that women had low representation in the national conference on institutional reforms in Niger, as well as in the elaboration process of the National Charter of Mali. It should also be noted that women continued to make a contribution to conflict prevention at the community level.

This shows the existing contradiction between the restructuring of the political institutions and the necessity of maintaining women's participation opportunities.

6. 2025–2026: Continuing challenges and the relevance of the agenda

The United Nations reporting in 2025 also pointed out that political transitions, violent extremism, humanitarian needs, and regional cooperation were some of the key challenges that needed to be faced in the Sahel.

The regional reporting done by the United Nations further highlighted the need for coordinated action that would address the root causes of instability rather than focusing only on security measures.

The WPS approach is significant for this period as well since it focuses on the link between women's participation and conflict prevention, peace-building, governance, and the protection of rights.

UNOWAS keeps supporting preventive diplomacy, inclusive political processes, and regional cooperation under its mandate. Such actions can be considered the institutional ground for engaging with the broader political and security challenges that face the region.

As part of the background guide prepared in October 2026, the period may be viewed as one that has not yet finished and requires the analysis of recent reports from the Secretary-General, UN Women, and official updates on national transition arrangements.

Current Situation

CRISIS IN THE SAHEL

The Sahel region faces enormous security challenges which are driven by political, geopolitical, socio-economic, and environmental factors.

This situation has also led to a growing humanitarian crisis, and the region has become a point of violent extremism.

The complex nature of this situation has impacted a lot of communities and contributed to a lack of public confidence in state institutions, which has been a huge factor behind a series of military coups in the region.

The Sahel crisis is multidimensional and requires multi-sectoral responses, including the contributions of all stakeholders, towards building peace. Women's contributions to the civilian response to the crisis are essential. This is where UN Women comes in.

In 2023, UN Women facilitated discussions to identify more effective strategies to strengthen women's leadership for peace.

With this in mind, in May UN Women helped organize a 3-day conference in Niger to allow participants to develop strategies to effectively adapt the women peace and security agenda to the situation in the Sahel. Participants included researchers, defense actors, regional organizations, and leaders of women's organizations, and they shared lessons learned and identified new approaches best suited to the context.

Starting in 2023, UN Women committed to building a strong movement of 100 women's organizations to promote peace in the Sahel.

UN Women has created spaces for exchange and sharing of experiences on the participation of women in political transition processes through webinars and forums.

The objective is to transform these transition contexts into opportunities to advance women's rights and improve governance in these countries.

While the region remains in crisis, UN Women is actively working with local partners to build the foundations for peace in the future.

1. Military transitions and political instability

The Sahel has experienced major political changes in recent years, particularly in Mali, Burkina Faso, and Niger. Mali experienced military coups in August 2020 and May 2021; Burkina Faso experienced two coups in 2022, and Niger experienced a coup in July 2023. These events changed the political leadership of the three countries and led to military-led transitional authorities.

These transitions have raised a lot of questions about constitutional governance, bringing back of civilian rule, and the participation of citizens in decisions about their country's future.

For women, political transitions can create additional barriers to participating in public meetings, political parties, government institutions, and peace programs.

Women's political agency involves more than being appointed to official positions. It also includes the ability to influence decisions, organize politically, express concerns, participate in negotiations, and hold authorities accountable. Ensuring that women are meaningfully included in transitional processes is therefore a very important part of building inclusive and stable institutions.
However, women are not only affected by conflict. They also contribute to preventing violence through community leadership, mediation, early warning initiatives, and peacebuilding. Their knowledge of local conditions can help identify tensions and support between communities.
Responses to violent extremism should therefore consider both security and human rights. Protecting civilians, supporting community-based prevention, and enabling women to participate in peace and security decisions are important aspects of a gender responsive approach.

2. Violent extremism and its impact on women

Violent extremist groups operating in parts of the Sahel have contributed to insecurity, displacement, and disruption of essential services. Armed violence can limit access to education, healthcare, markets, and public institutions. In affected communities, women may face additional restrictions on their movement and opportunities to participate in public life.
Insecurity can also make it more difficult for women to attend community meetings, organize political activities, or take part in peace negotiations.
Women who are community leaders or human rights defenders may face threats that discourage them from continuing their work.

3. Weakening state institutions and restrictions on civic participation

Effective state institutions are important for protecting political rights and ensuring that citizens can participate in public life. Courts, legislatures, electoral bodies and local administrations help establish accountability and provide channels through which citizens can raise concerns.
In parts of the Sahel, conflict, political instability and limited institutional capacity have made it more difficult for authorities to provide services and maintain public confidence. Political transitions can also create uncertainty about the functioning of oversight institutions and the protection of civic freedoms.
These challenges affect women when they have limited access to decision-making, face obstacles to organizing politically, or lack effective mechanisms for reporting intimidation and discrimination
Restrictions on civil society can further reduce the ability of women-led organizations to advocate for reforms and represent the needs of their communities
Strengthening institutions therefore requires more than improving their capacity to maintain security. It also involves accountability, access to justice, protection of civic freedoms and the inclusion of women in public decision-making.

4. Women’s political agency and participation

Women across the Sahel participate in political life through elected institutions, civil society organizations, community leadership, local mediation and peacebuilding initiatives. Women-led organizations can help communicate community concerns, encourage dialogue and support conflict prevention.

Despite these contributions, participation in local peacebuilding does not always translate into influence over national political decisions. Women may remain underrepresented in transitional authorities, formal negotiations and security decision-making. Their participation may also be limited by insecurity, inadequate funding, discrimination and restricted access to political institutions.

Meaningful political agency requires women to be able to participate safely and independently and to influence the decisions that affect their communities.

This includes access to consultations during political transitions, opportunities to contribute to peace agreements, and representation in institutions responsible for governance and security.

When we support these women-led organizations and help strengthen their access and standing in decision-making, we can help ensure that women’s experiences, views, and priorities are considered when policies are developed.

5. Displacement, poverty and humanitarian pressures

Conflict and insecurity have contributed to large-scale displacement across the Sahel. According to UNHCR's Global Report 2024 regional overview, the number of forcibly displaced people across the Sahel-plus area increased from 4.2 million in 2023 to 4.7 million in 2024. The figures cover Burkina Faso, Mali, Mauritania, Niger and affected areas of Benin, Côte d'Ivoire, Ghana and Togo.

Displacement can separate women from their homes, livelihoods, education and community networks. It can also make it harder for them to access public services and participate in community consultations or political activities. Women and girls in conflict-affected communities may face heightened protection risks, including gender-based violence.

Poverty and environmental pressures can further complicate the situation

Droughts, flooding, and pressure on agricultural and pastoral livelihoods may worsen existing economic difficulties and tensions over resources. These pressures interact with insecurity and governance challenges rather than operating independently.

Addressing displacement and poverty is therefore relevant to women's political agency. Women affected by conflict should be included in decisions concerning humanitarian assistance, livelihood recovery, local governance, and the future of their communities.

6. Regional cooperation and international partnerships

Regional cooperation has been affected by changes in political relationships between Sahelian states and regional organizations. Mali, Burkina Faso and Niger formed the Alliance of Sahel

States (AES) and subsequently withdrew from the Economic Community of West African States (ECOWAS). Their withdrawal became effective on 29 January 2025. ECOWAS stated that arrangements would continue temporarily to limit disruption while future relations were discussed.

These developments matter because regional organizations play roles in diplomacy, conflict prevention, governance, and development. Changes in regional relationships may affect how governments coordinate on shared security challenges and regional initiatives.

International partners also influence the region through diplomatic engagement, humanitarian assistance, development programmes, and security cooperation. Their relationships with individual governments have evolved, and their roles should be assessed using documented activities and policies.

For women's political agency, regional and international cooperation can provide opportunities to support women-led organizations, improve access to resources, promote inclusive political processes, and strengthen gender responsive peacebuilding. Such efforts need to take account of the different political circumstances of individual countries.

Stakeholders Analysis

1. National governments and transitional authorities

Mali

Mali is a central stakeholder because its political transition, security situation, and governance arrangements directly affect the conditions in which women participate in public life.
National authorities influence political consultations, institutional reforms, and the opportunities available to women-led organizations.

Burkina Faso

Burkina Faso faces serious insecurity and displacement, making civilian protection, local governance, and community peacebuilding important issues
Its authorities influence how women participate in public decision-making and how communities affected by conflict are represented in political processes.

Niger

Niger is relevant because the 2023 coup affected its political institutions and women's participation in decision-making
UN Women has reported challenges for women's and girls' rights following the coup, including declining representation in political life and economic pressures.

Other regional governments
Mauritania, Chad, Senegal, Ghana, Côte d'Ivoire, Benin, and Togo are relevant to different aspects of regional security, displacement, diplomacy, and cross-border cooperation
Their specific roles depend on their geographic position, national policies, and relationships with the countries most directly affected by the crisis.

Regional organizations

African Union (AU)

The AU provides continental frameworks for peace and security governance and gender equality
It is relevant to discussions about political transitions and the inclusion of women in peace and security decision-making.

Economic Community of West African States (ECOWAS)

ECOWAS has played an important role in regional diplomacy, political dialogue, and conflict prevention
Its relationship with Mali, Burkina Faso, and Niger changed following their withdrawal in January 2025.

Maintaining channels for regional dialogue remains relevant to cooperation on security and development.

Alliance of Sahel States (AES)
The AES brings together Mali, Burkina Faso, and Niger.
It is relevant to regional coordination on security and political cooperation.

UN Women
UN Women works to advance gender equality and women's empowerment. Its work focuses on women's political participation, leadership, and peacebuilding.

UN Office for West Africa and the Sahel (UNOWAS)
UNOWAS supports diplomacy, political engagement, and peace and security efforts in West Africa and the Sahel.

United Nations Development Programme (UNDP)
UNDP supports governance, institutional capacity and development. Its work is relevant to strengthening public institutions and creating conditions for more inclusive decision-making.

Office of the UN High Commissioner for Human Rights (OHCHR)
OHCHR promotes and monitors human rights. It is relevant to protecting civic freedoms, addressing discrimination and supporting accountability for violations affecting women's political participation.

United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR)
UNHCR protects refugees and supports responses to forced displacement. Its work is relevant to the protection of displaced women and girls and to ensuring that their needs are considered in humanitarian responses.

UN Security Council
The Security Council addresses international peace and security. Its Women, Peace and Security framework is relevant to women's participation in conflict prevention, peace negotiations and post-conflict decision-making. Unlike CSW, it is not primarily a gender equality policy commission.
They can contribute to conflict prevention, community dialogue, early warning, political advocacy, and peacebuilding. They can also communicate the concerns of women who may not have access to formal political institutions.
But still, these organizations may have to face funding shortages, security risks, restrictions on civic participation, and limited access to formal negotiations. Supporting their independence and ensuring that they can participate safely are important considerations for the committee, as they will benefit it.

These groups are relevant to the agenda because insecurity can make it more difficult for women to participate in political activities, organize community initiatives, or engage in peacebuilding. The committee's role is not to plan military operations. Instead, it should consider the gender related consequences of insecurity, civilian protection, prevention of violent extremism and the need to protect women's rights during security responses.
The European Union, France, the United States, Russia and China are relevant to different aspects of diplomacy, economic cooperation, development and security. Their relationships with individual Sahelian states are not identical and should be assessed separately.

For this agenda, an important issue is how international partnerships can support inclusive governance, women's political participation and civilian protection. Development and humanitarian programmes can also help women-led organizations access resources and participate in community recovery.

Challenges and Gaps

The central issue before this commission is not the lack of commitments and actions to recognize and secure women's political agency; rather, these commitments exist more in principle and lack enforcement, funding, and protection during crises, especially in the Sahel region.

Repeated coups, Jihadist violence, shrinking of civic space, and weak institutions that lack enforcement have made these commitments difficult to enforce and protect properly.

The primary framework is the UN Women**, Peace and Security (WPS) agenda**, anchored in **UN Security Council Resolution 1325 (2000).** It is the primary lens through which UNCSW should address women's political agency during military transitions, violent extremism, and weakening state institutions in the Sahel.

The WPS agenda recognizes that women are not only victims of conflict but are key factors in preventing and combating violence, building peace, and developing societies. It calls for the participation of women in political and security decision-making, alongside the protection of women from conflict-based violence.

Adopted in 2000 as part of UNSCR 1325, it links gender equality to international peace and security and aims to combat conflict and violence.

The three main pillars of the WPS include-
PARTICIPATION - Women should have meaningful participation rather than merely being observers or symbolic representatives
PROTECTION- Women should be protected, and it is an integral part of participation, as they can not participate with violence, insecurity, intimidation, etc.
PREVENTION - Prevention and relief of conflict and violence, addressing root causes for such issues and putting in measures for prevention.
RELIEF- Post conflict relief and assistance must respond to the needs of women such as access to food, water, healthcare, education, and economic opportunities.

RELEVANCE OF WPS TO THE ISSUE IN THE SAHEL
The WPS agenda matters in the Sahel because, as mentioned previously, it prevents women from being seen exclusively as victims of conflict and violence; hence, it recognizes them as peacebuilders, leaders, decision-makers, and a primary part of solving the issue in the Sahel region. In the Sahel, women are often central to local conflict prevention, humanitarian response, education, reconciliation, and community resilience, yet they remain underrepresented in formal peace and security institutions.

ISSUES WITHIN THE WPS IN THE SAHEL
Participation is often symbolic, which means that though women are invited to meetings, consultations, etc. They often lack meaningful participation as they often lack voting power, influence, and access to decision-making bodies.

Several Sahel countries have gender-quota laws, including Mali, Niger, and Burkina Faso.

However, quotas may apply only to candidate lists rather than guaranteed seats, and enforcement is weak.

Hence, women may appear on party lists but remain underrepresented or have no proper voice in parliaments, cabinets, transitional councils, and peace negotiations.

Many countries do have WPS agenda National Action Plans (NAP's), but they often lack proper funding, monitoring, and consequences for non-implementation.

Counter terrorism also does not account for gender. This is a major issue as women experience insecurity in different ways, as they can be subjected to femicide, loss of education, sexual violence, economic exclusion, and be restricted by armed groups.

Military governments have also limited expression, protests, freedom of the press, political opposition, etc., which is a significant issue as most women's organisations rely on public advocacy, international partnerships, etc.

Another convention that plays a significant role in this agenda is the Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination Against Women (CEDAW), which was adopted in 1979 and is the main global human-rights treaty on women's equality. It requires the elimination of discrimination against women in domestic, public, private, and professional settings.
Relevant articles include
ARTICLE 7 - Guarantees equal rights to vote, participate, represent, etc. to women.
ARTICLE 8 - Requires states to enable women to represent and participate in international affairs and organisations.

RELEVANCE OF CEDAW
CEDAW provides the legal basis to argue that women in the Sahel must have equal access to elections, public office, political parties, transitional institutions, peace processes, and decision-making bodies. It also reinforces the Maputo Protocol and WPS agenda.

ISSUES WITHIN CEDAW

Though CEDAW is legally binding on the states that ratify it, it does not equate to strong enforcement. It strongly lacks enforcement and implementation. Equality between men and women is formally guaranteed by the constitutions of many Sahel states. For instance, the Constitution of Mali does not make any formal distinction between men and women in respect of political and public life.

Nevertheless, the fact that there is formal equality does not eliminate structural obstacles such as poverty, insecurity, lack of education, the restriction of access by political parties, violence, and social norms. Although Burkina Faso acknowledges equal political rights, women are still underrepresented in government, in parliament, and in public administration.

Equality between men and women is provided for in the constitutions of many of the states in the Sahel. For example, the Constitution of Mali contains no formal distinction between men and women with regard to political and public life.

Yet the existence of formal equality does not remove structural difficulties such as poverty, insecurity, lack of education, the limitation of access by political parties, violence, and social norms. Though Burkina Faso recognizes equal political rights, women are still not well represented in government, in parliament, and in public administration.

MAPUTO PROTOCOL

The **Maputo Protocol**—formally the *Protocol to the African Charter on Human and Peoples' Rights on the Rights of Women in Africa*- is the most important African regional legal framework for women's political agency. Put into force in 2005, it requires African states to take active steps to promote women's equal participation in political and public life.

Important articles in this protocol include Article 9, which is crucial to this issue. It complements CEDAW and UNSCR 1325. Maputo Protocol provides an African regional obligation to use affirmative action to make participation real.

GAPS IN MAPUTO PROTOCOL

Though the protocol creates obligations for the states, it has to be incorporated into national law for it to have any real impact.

Article 9 does support affirmative action. However, many states have not transformed it into enforceable action; rather, it only applies to candidate lists where quota laws exist, and consequences are often weak for those who do not comply. The Protocol assumes functioning democratic institutions, but coups in Mali, Burkina Faso, and Niger have concentrated power in military-led transitional authorities.

Niger has signed but not ratified the Protocol, so it should not be presented as bound by it in the same way as Mali and Burkina Faso.

These authorities may reshape constitutions, electoral rules, and peace processes with limited women's participation. In Mali, only 2 of the 36 members drafting the new national charter were women, showing how transitional processes can exclude women despite regional legal commitments.

Even if legal rights do exist, violent extremism often restricts women's freedom, education, rights, and participation. It cannot, on its own, protect women from abduction, sexual violence, displacement, or threats from armed groups.

The Protocol relies heavily on state reporting and regional institutions for follow-up. However, monitoring is often weak, and there are limited consequences for governments that fail to implement Article 9.

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